

In, on, and at

Teaching guide

Say where something is and when it happens.

Understand the distinction

Use in for an area or a period: in Seoul, in a box, in July. Use on for a surface or a particular day: on the table, on Tuesday. Use at for a point or an exact time: at the entrance, at 9:30.

These are starting patterns, not rules for every phrase. Learn common expressions as units: at home, at night, in the morning. In a building stresses being inside; at a building can name a meeting point.

Compare the patterns

IN

I live in Lima.

Lima is an area.

ON

The class is on Friday.

Friday is a particular day.

AT

Meet me at the entrance at six.

Both phrases identify a point.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. The call starts ___ 10:15 a.m.

A. on

B. in

C. at

2. The keys are resting on the table surface, not below it or inside it. Choose: The keys are ___ the kitchen table.

A. under

B. on

C. in

3. Choose the correction: We met in Monday.

A. We met to Monday.

B. We met at Monday.

C. We met on Monday.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You want to invite a friend to the library on Saturday at eleven. Which invitation uses the correct prepositions?

- A. Meet me in the library in Saturday on eleven.
- B. Meet me at the library at Saturday in eleven.
- C. Meet me at the library on Saturday at eleven.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. at

An exact time takes at.

A: Use at for a clock time; on introduces a day or date.

B: Use at for a precise clock time; in is used for periods such as a month.

2. B. on

The keys are resting on a surface.

A: Under would put the keys below the table. They are resting on its surface.

C: In would place the keys inside something. The sentence describes a surface.

3. C. We met on Monday.

Use on with a named day.

A: To does not introduce the day when a meeting happened.

B: Use on before a day of the week.

4. C. Meet me at the library on Saturday at eleven.

At introduces the place and clock time; on introduces the day.

A: Use on Saturday and at eleven. In the library is possible, but the time phrases here are wrong.

B: Use on for Saturday and at for the clock time.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-01.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

You want to invite a friend to the library on Saturday at eleven. Which invitation uses the correct prepositions?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.